

US: Driscoll first casualty of 2028 GOP jockeying

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【メール原文】

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Venezuela oil deal ties Trump more tightly to Rodriguez

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Managed decoupling will define US-China relations through 2031

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US-Iran standoff now likely to run through 2026

Driscoll first casualty of 2028 GOP jockeying. Secretary of the Army Dan Driscoll handed in his resignation yesterday, after previously announcing his intention to leave at year's end. The reasons for Driscoll's departure weren't publicly disclosed, but he and Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth—who is setting up a 2028 presidential run and seeking to “own” the Department of Defense as part of his intra-party appeal—were often at odds during his tenure, especially on personnel and promotion decisions.

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Driscoll's resignation leaves the Army without its top two Senate-confirmed leaders; the Army Chief of Staff role has been filled by a Hegseth ally, Chris LaNeve, whose nomination has received pushback on Capitol Hill and is unlikely to move forward in the near term. On the civilian side, Pentagon Spokesman Sean Parnell and Under Secretary of the Army Michael Obadal are early favorites to replace Driscoll.

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The Army's initiatives to procure, test, and field nascent drone technologies will be left in a lurch in Driscoll's absence. In addition to Driscoll, Secretary Hegseth personally forced out former Army Chief of Staff Randy George in April. Driscoll applied his background in venture capital alongside George's military acumen to co-lead the service's dedicated drone programs and testing unit, which Hegseth disbanded last month – ultimately leaving the service's drone acquisition and fielding efforts rudderless.

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Even if the jostling for the 2028 presidential nomination was not the precipitating factor in Driscoll's departure, it is an important piece of the background context. Hegseth, who visited the Iowa State Fair earlier this month, harbors clear presidential ambitions, and removing Driscoll—a close ally of Vice

President JD Vance—is in part a power play meant to consolidate Hegseth’s control over the Pentagon.

Venezuela oil deal ties Trump more tightly to Rodriguez. The US plan to jointly develop 17 Venezuelan oil fields through a Pentagon office is highly unusual but can help to catalyze investment in the oil sector, raise output, and deepen US involvement. The Pentagon’s Office of Strategic Capital will develop the fields—accessing over 65 billion barrels of oil—in partnership with a private operator, taking a 35% stake in the venture.

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The agreement would potentially help to lift Venezuela’s oil output, though it is unclear how much will be executed at this point. It could also catalyze US investment in Venezuela by signaling a long-term policy commitment; this has been one of the main concerns for foreign oil firms.

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The deal also speaks to President Donald Trump’s commitment to Venezuelan President Delcy Rodriguez; oil-related benefits will diminish his incentives to push for new elections.

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For more, please see Unprecedented oil deal will reinforce Trump’s commitment to Rodriguez , 31 August 2026.

Managed decoupling will define US-China relations through 2031. The US-China truce will likely hold through the rest of Trump’s term, but both sides are using the time to de-risk. Our basecase through 2026 is that managed decoupling within the Busan framework largely survives (60% odds), but we have raised the odds of a breakdown to 30% (from 20%) because of friction over AI and widening commercial restrictions.

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We also expect managed decoupling as our basecase through 2031 (60% odds), with the downside scenario of escalation more likely than de-escalation. However, neither country will eliminate the other’s coercive leverage within five years.

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A post-Trump administration will probably be less accommodating of President Xi Jinping, moving away from the completely transactional approach Trump has adopted. Different post-Trump scenarios would all probably retain some tariffs, outbound screening, and chip controls.

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For more, please see Managed decoupling will define US-China relations through 2031 , 27 August 2026.

US-Iran standoff now likely to run through 2026. We now see a deal to reopen Hormuz as unlikely this year (15% odds, down from 55%), with a prolonged standoff that includes occasional flare-ups our new basecase (60%, up from 20%).

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US success at increasing traffic through Hormuz and Iranian resilience in the face of stepped-up economic pressure have led us to revise our odds. Iran is unwilling to shift its negotiating position, and the US appears uninterested in reviving the June MoU.

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Oil flows through the Strait of Hormuz average 7-8 million bpd; combined with flows through alternative routes, regional exports are roughly at 60% prewar levels. This alleviates immediate pressure on the US from high oil prices, but the persistence of elevated prices will eventually become a headwind for

President Trump as the US further draws down its SPR stockpiles.

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For more, please see Standoff now likely to run through 2026 as Hormuz traffic increases , 31 August 2026.

Quote of the Day

"The only reason that communities throughout the U.S.A. should not want Data Centers is if they want to end up being backwards and poor. If they want to be successful and rich, with far lower taxes and jobs all over the place, let Data Reign." – President Trump on Truth Social yesterday. Trump's remarks place him on the opposite side of a growing political divide in the Republican Party; scores of high-level Republicans, including Texas Governor Greg Abbott, have positioned themselves against data centers in recent weeks, in response to boiling-over public pressure on the issue. But with the remarks, Trump is signaling that data-center development still has the robust support of the White House. That support remains a bullish sign for the industry, especially if the tide of anti-data-center sentiment recedes after the midterms.

On the Radar

10 August – 14 September: Senate on recess

1 September: Massachusetts primaries

8 September: Canadian retaliatory tariffs go into effect

9-10 September: GOP midterms convention

18-28 September: High-Level Week at UN General Assembly

24 September: Trump-Xi summit

30 September: Government funding runs out

3 November: National midterm elections

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